



Venice's modern splendor is the result of control of the lucrative trade routes between Europe, the Byzantine Empire, and the East in the 10th century.

IN 981, THE ISLAMIC FORCES OF CORDOBA defeated the Christian kingdom of **León** in Spain, under the leadership of **Al-Mansur**. "Al-Mansur" was the honorific title taken by Muhammad ibn Abi Amir, the powerful and energetic vizier who was the true power behind the **Umayyad** throne (see 911–20). He campaigned successfully against León, Navarre, and Catalonia, making their kings subordinate to the caliphate, and extended Umayyad control to Africa via campaigns in **Mauretania** (modern-day Morocco and part of Algeria).

In 986, the Viking explorer **Eric the Red** led a party of Icelandic colonists to the shores of the bleak landmass he misleadingly named



Al-Mansur
This 17th century oil painting depicts Al Mansur, or Almanzor to his Christian subordinates. Al Mansur means "the Victorious."

"Greenland" in the hope of attracting settlers. He succeeded in recruiting 24 boatloads of men, women, and children willing to entrust their lives to Viking longboats and brave the perilous crossing. Only 14 ships arrived, but they quickly established a thriving colony that may have eventually numbered around 5,000 people.

Otto II, the emperor and king of East Francia, died of malaria in

983 after an expedition to southern Italy. Although his infant son, **Otto III** (r. 983–1001), managed to hold on to the crown thanks to the strong regency of his mother, Theophano, the East Franks were also faced with an uprising among the **Wends**, the forcibly converted Slavic tribes on the eastern border. The Wends restored their pagan religion and resisted Frankish colonization for nearly two centuries.

In 987, **Toltec** forces conquered the Yucatán Maya and made **Chichen Itza** the capital of a Toltec–Maya state. According to the early Mayan chronicle *Chilam*

Balam, Chichen Itza was conquered by Toltecs led by Kukulcan, the Mayan name for the Toltec god Quetzlcoatl or "the feathered serpent"—possibly the exiled Toltec king, Topiltzin. Despite the record in the chronicle, however, archaeological findings suggest that the city collapsed around this time.

By the end of the 10th century, the mercantile powers of **Venice** and **Genoa** were beginning to dominate the Adriatic and Tyrrhenian seas, respectively. Venice, in particular, enjoyed lucrative trade links with the Byzantine Empire.



TOLTECS

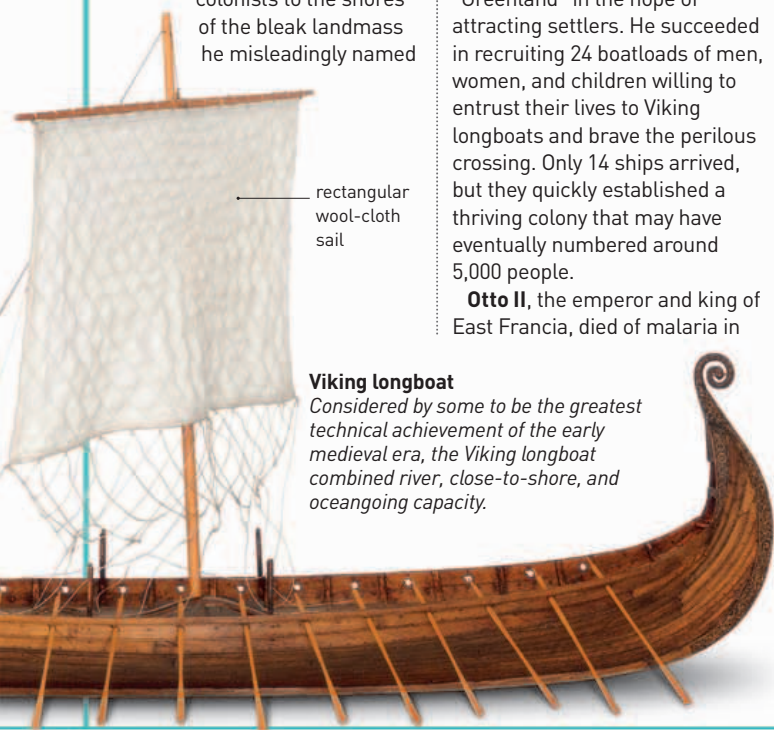
The Toltecs, who ruled a state centered on Tula in modern-day Mexico, were notable for their aggressive militarism, which changed society in Central America, paving the way for militaristic states such as the Aztec. The term "Toltec" came to mean "city-dweller" or "civilized person," but its literal meaning is "reed person"—signifying an inhabitant of Tollan ("Place of the Reeds," the city now known as Tula). Toltec art and architecture, characterized by monumental masonry and giant statues, was greatly influential in the region.

22,000 POUNDS THE WEIGHT IN SILVER OF THE DANEGELD IN 991

IN 991, A FORCE OF ANGLO-SAXON WARRIORS made a stand against a much larger army of Vikings at the **Battle of Maldon** in East Anglia, England. They were slaughtered. The English king, **Aethelred II**, "the Unready" (r. 978–1016), was forced to pay a tribute known as the **Danegeld**, to buy off further incursions.

Byzantine emperor **Basil II** launched the first of a long series of campaigns against his greatest enemy, the **Bulgarian czar** Samuel, in 996. Basil had won major victories in Syria the year before, but it took him nearly 20 years to finally defeat the Bulgarians.

From around 1000, the inhabitants of **Easter Island**, or **Rapa Nui**—an island in the Pacific Ocean—began to carve monumental statues known as *moai*. Thought to represent ancestors and to channel *mana*—spiritual energy—the cult of *moai* consumed the Easter Islanders to the point where they may have fatally compromised their environment—setting them on the path to ecological disaster.



Viking longboat

Considered by some to be the greatest technical achievement of the early medieval era, the Viking longboat combined river, close-to-shore, and oceangoing capacity.

rectangular wool-cloth sail

